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Original Page: 306**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** June 1967-April 1969**Coverage Date:** 1963-1973**Place Coverage:** Dobe Area, Botswana**Section Title(S):** The Cultural Definitions Of Kinship

The Cultural Definitions of Kinship

The !Kung, like people everywhere, have a system for organizing the facts of biological relatedness (and fictional relationships) into categories of terminology that imply obligations and responsibilities between pairs of people. This system is well described by Marshall (1976:201) for the Nyae Nyae !Kung; it generally applies to the Dobe !Kung as well. The kinship system of the !Kung is bilateral (rather than lineal) and is based on a shallow depth, which means that relationships that would be traced through common ancestors long dead tend to be ignored, or forgotten. It is rare for !Kung to trace relationships beyond that of the generation of the oldest living people (although deceased members of that generation will often be evoked to trace a relationship). Coincidentally, the !Kung kin terms correspond quite closely to the familiar kin terminology of American society (aunts, uncles, cousins, nephews, etc.), differing from these categories primarily by the !Kung addition of a relative age term in each, and the addition of categories of "joking" and "avoidance" to the meanings of the terms. Since we are using an unfamiliar methodology in this chapter, it will increase clarity to report the results in the familiar categories, which we can do without committing real violence to the social reality of the !Kung. All of the categories used here are important ones for the !Kung, and there are few strong ties (mostly based on the name relationships) that are excluded from this category system.

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